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ISSN: 1473-5784 (Print) 1473-5776 (Online) Journal homepage: www.tandfonline.com/journals/rctc20

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To cite this article: Rüstem Ertuğ Altınay (14 Jan 2025): When the queen of transvestites revealed it all? Performative politics of queer life writing in Turkey's era of confession, Culture, Theory and Critique, DOI: 10.1080/14735784.2024.2416650

To link to this article: https://doi.org/10.1080/14735784.2024.2416650

Published online: 14 Jan 2025.

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CULTURE, THEORY AND CRITIQUE
https://doi.org/10.1080/14735784.2024.2416650

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When the queen of transvestites revealed it all? Performative politics of queer life writing in Turkey's era of confession

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ABSTRACT
After the coup d'état of 1980, as a neoliberal regime was gradually established in Turkey, confession gained unprecedented power as a disciplinary technology. Several queer subjects created auto/biographical texts and performances as they negotiated the gendered and sexualised politics of confessional citizenship. Ümit Oğuztan's documentary novel *Kraliçe Sisi* [Queen Sisi] (1991) was of exceptional significance. Oğuztan claimed to narrate the high-end trans sex worker Seyhan Soylu's life and her sexual experiences with Turkey's elite. The author employed archival and ethnographic research methods and performative writing techniques to create a truth effect while preventing trouble with the law. By queering iconic figures, *Kraliçe Sisi* proposed an alternative perspective on the past and explored the possibility of a different future. This example of liberal pornography queered its readers by providing an opportunity for identification and empathy, and by producing non-normative sexual desires in and through their bodies. The accounts of the book's trans readers show how this notorious text performed a work of activism and changed lives. Rather than an unconditional investment in liberatory politics, however, *Kraliçe Sisi* harbours strong ambivalences and discriminatory discourses, revealing the diverse, at times unsettling forms queer literature and memory practices can take.

KEYWORDS
Turkey; queer; literature

Introduction

Sisi stood before the woman and slowly took her clothes off. It must have been the first time that İnci saw a transvestite. She first looked at the beauty of Sisi's breasts as if she were mesmerised. Once Sisi took her panties off and İnci saw the male organ in front of her, she could not take her wide-open eyes off it. Sisi realised that she was taken by the desire to own İnci's well-groomed body. … Suddenly, she felt a strange grudge against the lives of Ender and his wife. She became aware of the hatred, resentment, and roughness in the way she had İnci only as she reached an orgasm. Ender dried himself well after the shower, entered the bed, and started making love with Sisi. Her having had his wife had turned him on a lot. Sisi was surprised that Ender took her so roughly. She realised that another person having had his wife turned him on in some weird way. … Ender Ak, the owner of İnşaat Bankası [Construction Bank], was a respectable person and an elite member of the society. His wife İnci Güney was a very reputable lady in Istanbul's jet set and a former

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> fashion model! She was different from them; she was an ostracised, humiliated, disgraced person. Why?[1] (Oğuztan 1991, 291–292)

A product of Turkey's era of confession in the long 1980s, Ümit Oğuztan's documentary novel *Kraliçe Sisi* [Queen Sisi] (1991) claims to narrate the life and sexual experiences of the high-end trans sex worker and performer Seyhan Soylu, also known as Sisi, the Queen of Transvestites. As a collaborative memory project, *Kraliçe Sisi* proposes a queer formulation of Turkey's recent past, mainly by claiming to reveal the unknown sexual histories of the country's cultural, political, and business elite. As it fundamentally redefines the sexualities and thereby identities of these respectable citizens, the book also challenges the gendered and sexualised politics of belonging in Turkey and invites its readers to imagine alternative futures.

Kraliçe Sisi's power as a queer memory project largely lies in the diverse literary techniques Ümit Oğuztan employs. The author's performative writing strategies help him negotiate the liminal space between fiction and non-fiction while also producing the desired truth effect. Oğuztan's use of progressive and liberal discourses – such as democracy, equality, LGBTIQ+ rights, and individual liberties – in entanglement with a pornographic narrative provides readers with sexual excitement as well as a sense of moral and political self-affirmation at the same time. The pornographic content of the book also potentially queers the readers, both by enabling empathy and identification with the trans protagonist, and by producing sexual desire through descriptions of non-normative practices of pleasure. As it interpellates readers, of whatever gender and sexual identification, as queer subjects, the book opens up structures of desire and identification, and fosters the imagination of a different, less bimodal future. The accounts of the book's trans readers show that *Kraliçe Sisi* helped them make sense of their own experiences and imagine a community to which they did not otherwise have access.

The queer politics of *Kraliçe Sisi* are far from an unqualified investment in a liberatory agenda. While explicitly criticising the hegemonic culture of confession that emerged from the dynamics of neoliberalisation in Turkey in the 1980s, the book still participates in this culture. Even more importantly, *Kraliçe Sisi* is rife with discriminatory discourses, ranging from the denigration of Armenian subjects to ageism, misogyny, and even transphobia. As such, the book reveals the complexities that define queer history and politics in Turkey as well as the possibilities and limitations involved in queer archives of abjection. *Kraliçe Sisi* thus challenges the tendency in the scholarship to associate queer memory projects, especially those from the Middle East, with progressive goals. This association, on the one hand, is a consequence of the prevalent activist concerns in queer studies, which have been particularly influential in the scholarship on Turkey. It also reflects the victimising frameworks that have shaped the liberal Western European and North American academia's approach to queer subjects in or from Islamicate contexts, which often define them primarily as targets of Islamophobia, anti-immigrant sentiments and policies, imperialism, and settler colonialism at the expense of ignoring the complexity of their political subjectivities and investments (Altınay 2014). At a time

[1]All translations by the author unless indicated otherwise. *Travesti* [transvestite] was a common term defining trans women in Turkish when the book was published. I use the feminine gender pronoun to refer to Sisi because that is her primary gender identification. Nevertheless, Turkish is a gender-neutral language, and the book's approach to gender and trans phenomena is more complicated.

when homophobia and transphobia are on the rise in Turkey as in many other right-wing populist regimes, *Kraliçe Sisi* demonstrates the possibility of alternative queer cultural production forms while also reminding us of the diversity and ambivalences that continue to characterise queer political projects today.

The rise of confessional citizenship in neoliberal Turkey

Kraliçe Sisi was both a product of and an intervention in the unprecedented rise of confession as a 'disciplinary technology', producing and regulating subjects in the context of neoliberalisation in Turkey in the 1980s (Foucault 1977). Turkey's entry into the decade was marked by a coup d'état on September 12, 1980. During a time when the country was highly politicised, the military used social disorder as a pretext to suppress the left, and to facilitate Turkey's integration into the global market economy with a shift from statist developmentalism to export-driven market capitalism (Adak and Altınay 2018). The coup's economic programme also included the implementation of a free internal market, cutting wages and subsidies (Zürcher 2004, 5).

The first civilian government after the coup was established in 1983 by Turgut Özal's center-right Anavatan Partisi [Motherland Party] or ANAP, which remained in power until 1991. As cultural critic Nurdan Gürbilek (2011) argues, the ANAP years were characterised by neoliberal policies fostered by the reconciliation of two ostensibly conflicting governmental strategies that parallelled the Foucauldian critique of the repressive hypothesis, albeit with contextual differences in the institutions and technologies of power (Foucault 1978). Foucault's analysis challenges the assumption that the rise of the bourgeoisie and capitalism in Europe imposed silence on issues of sexuality beginning in the seventeenth century (1978, 17). Instead, he demonstrates what was at stake

> was the multiplication of discourses concerning sex in the field of exercise of power itself: an institutional incitement to speak about it, and to do so more and more; a determination on the part of the agencies of power to hear it spoken about, and to cause *it* to speak through explicit articulation and endlessly accumulated detail. (Foucault 1978, 18)

What emerged was not so much an absolute censorship on matters of sexuality but rather an incitement to discourse where confessions about sexuality became a vital element of new governmental mechanisms (Foucault 1978). Similar dynamics defined Turkey's age of confession.

Post-coup Turkey, on the one hand, was still a period of oppression characterised by a 'repression of speech' (Gürbilek 2011, 8). The politicians who were banned after the coup could not resume their political activities until 1987. Workers' unions had lost their power in organising and bargaining. Many leaders and members of socialist movements had been executed or were in prison or exile, and the remaining groups were marginalised and criminalised. The bans on the stage work of trans performers and the production of erotic and pornographic movies – which also featured trans women actors – initially imposed by the junta government, persisted.[2] Trans women and gay men, especially sex workers (which was the only line of employment available to many of them), were subjected to intense police violence, house raids, and exiles (Baykan 2020,

[2]The ban on the stage work of trans performers was lifted in 1988, but the junta regime permanently terminated Turkey's once vibrant erotic movie industry and the queer possibilities it involved.

494). Individuals diagnosed with HIV were criminalised and confined to social as well as physical isolation (Altınay 2024).

Despite the continuing political oppression, the dominant strategy of power in Turkey combined the 'repression of speech' with the 'explosion of speech' as it aimed 'to encircle by speech rather than silence, transform rather than prohibit, internalise rather than destroy, tame rather than suppress' (Gürbilek 2011, 6–8). In the context of neoliberalising Turkey, sustained by the discourses of individualism and cultural pluralism, while cultural identities could be expressed independently from political movements, political ideologies were redefined as matters of identity. The public sphere in its conventional sense thus became apoliticised and privatised while cultural and political demands were largely subsumed under market capitalism (Gürbilek 2011). The void left by the exclusion of the explicitly political from the public sphere was filled by what used to be conceptualised as the private – as dramatically seen in the transformation of mainstream media and the rise of celebrity journalism.

In her groundbreaking work on the politics of confession in Turkey, Gürbilek (2011, 40) distinguishes between the explosion of speech, characterised by the scientific discourse and the involvement of experts, and a more modern confessional project of the aestheticization of experience legitimised under the sign of 'individual freedom'. I would argue, however, that these two categories that existed together were not always easily distinguishable. Their intersections and interactions even inspired new cultural production formats, as best exemplified by the magazine *Gözde Kadın* [The Popular Woman] (1985–1986). The monthly magazine dedicated each issue to one young female celebrity, such as Güngör Bayrak, Serpil Çakmaklı, Sevtap Parman or Yaprak Özdemiroğlu. Alongside dozens of glamour shots of the same woman in different sets, the magazine also featured photographs documenting her past as well as lengthy interviews where she narrated her life, sexual experiences, and fantasies. Each issue concluded with a section titled 'Yargılanması' ['Her Trial'], where the woman's friends, colleagues, and in some cases family members made comments about her and a psychiatry professor affiliated with Istanbul University offered a diagnosis based on their accounts and the woman's confessions. The medicalised conclusion to these comprehensive catalogues of confession differentiated *Gözde Kadın* from its competitors such as *Erkekçe* [Manly] or *Playmen*, which often featured confessional material as well. The medicalisation of confession legitimised the erotic content and the experience of reading *Gözde Kadın* – particularly by demonstrating the willingness of an expert affiliated with Turkey's most prestigious medical school to collaborate with the magazine. Even more importantly, confession involves a form of power-knowledge where 'the agency of domination does not reside in the person that speaks, but in the one who questions and listens' (Besley 2005, 83). The expert's account – which provides a narrative structure for the readers to make sense of the catalogue of confession – thus also enhances the erotic pleasure derived from reading by offering the power associated with medical authority as well.

As the subjects who made their political investments primarily through identity politics attempted to attain the neoliberal promise of freedom and to cultivate a sense of belonging to the nation-state by gaining visibility in the public sphere, confession emerged as a central disciplinary technology. Since the political and affective bond with the nation was imagined and experienced through performances of confession,

what I term 'confessional citizenship' came to play a significant role in defining the politics of belonging.

Confessional citizenship was a mode of citizenship where the relationship between the individual and the state was sutured by way of an identification with the nation through a willingness to make public what was commonly defined as the private or *mahram* [*mahrem* in Turkish]. The word 'mahram' means 'the forbidden' and it refers to a private, often sexual realm confined by normative boundaries (Sehlikoğlu 2015, 236). The relationship between the confessions about the mahram lives of individuals, which were often sexual in nature, and the nation was established through the discourse of *namus* [honour].

In Turkey, honour operates as what Victor Turner defines as a 'root paradigm', a 'consciously recognised (though only on occasions of raised consciousness) cultural [model] of an allusive, metaphorical kind, cognitively delimited, emotionally loaded and ethically impelled, so as to give form to action in publicly critical circumstances' (1977, 74). Gender is at the core of the definitions of honour. Women's honour is defined primarily in terms of refraining from non-normative gendered and sexualised behaviour – however these may be understood by specific actors at a certain time. The primary indicators of men's honour, on the other hand, are the ability to control the sexualities of the women a man is considered to be responsible for and, usually to a lesser extent, honesty in public affairs. Although too often ignored in scholarly and public debates, as *Kraliçe Sisi* also reminds us, heterosexuality and normative gender identity are important identifiers of honour.

While it is a concept linked with sexuality and sexual behaviour, honour emerges as 'both the identity of the person vis-à-vis others and the sense of worth that a person has of himself or herself; it is the internalised form of a person's social standing' (Sirman 2004, 44). In Turkey, where the citizens' presumed responsibilities to the nation-state are formulated in terms of honour, there is an intrinsic connection between honour and the politics of belonging. Through the laws, norms and discourses on gender, honour has also been incorporated into legislation (İlkkaracan 2008, 51). As such, honour plays a key role in defining citizenship in everyday as well as legal contexts. Hence the performances of sexual confession, which were always about honour, were performances of citizenship.

Confession is a ritual 'in which the expression alone, independently of its external consequences, produces intrinsic modifications in the person who articulates it: it exonerates, redeems, and purifies him; it unburdens him of his wrongs, liberates him, and promises him salvation' (Foucault 1978, 62). In the case of secular confession in the Islamicate context of Turkey, there was no necessary relationship between confession and a sense of redemption as implied by Christian rituals. Nor were all confessions characterised by contrition. In these performances, confessants emerged as political subjects by publicising their mahram, and they experienced a momentary union with the nation, which they posited as the confessor.

Cultural theorists Lauren Berlant and Michael Warner suggest that the banalisation of intimacy through confessional performances serves to produce the hegemonic social and cultural codes and secure heterosexual public culture, its prospects and promises (1998, 556). These dynamics formed a crucial aspect of the confessional performances of citizenship in Turkey. As 'dishonourable' subjects narrated their personal histories, they

emerged as what Karen Shimakawa (2002) describes as 'national abjects'. Shimakawa's work builds on Julia Kristeva's (1982) account of subject-formation, according to which the subject comes into consciousness and maintains it by constructing perceptual and conceptual borders around the self and jettisoning that which is deemed objectionable. Shimakawa demonstrates how these dynamics operate on the national level, arguing that national abjects occupy 'a role both necessary to and mutually constitutive of national subject formation' (Shimakawa 2002, 3). As individuals came to occupy the public sphere through confessing their loss of honour, they emerged as national abjects, simultaneously producing fascination and loathing in the subjects who complied with the codes of normative citizenship. As such, while confessional citizenship may appear to be of relevance to only a limited number of people who did engage in such performances, the mutually constitutive nature of national abjection fundamentally enhanced the significance of this mode of citizenship.

In the performances that did involve an element of contrition, the confessing subjects attempted to distance themselves from the position of abjection while affirming the existence of this position. These performances thus reproduced the conceptual and perceptual borders of the Turkish nation. An early yet striking example of such performances was the trans singer Bülent Ersoy's cult film, *Şöhretin Sonu* [The End of Fame] (dir. Orhan Aksoy 1981). This semi – (or pseudo-) autobiographical film narrates the famous singer's troubled relationships with society. To make sense of his[3] trans experiences, Ersoy seeks the help of a psychiatrist, to whom he confesses the intimate details of his life. The film ends with the singer entering into a fight with the fiancée of a conductor, in whom Ersoy had a romantic interest. At the court, where the singer appears in male drag, the judge who releases him advises Ersoy against setting a bad example to the public. When the judge tells him to try to be beneficial and not harmful to the society to whom he owes everything he has, Ersoy responds that he will remember this advice all his life. During a time when the singer negotiated her trans identity with the junta government and the public, this confessional film that ends with a scene of contrition and detransitioning probably aimed to create public sympathy. The self-distancing from transness as a position of abjection in the film, however, did not happen in real life. Like other trans performers, Ersoy's stage performances were thus also banned in 1981, the year the film was released (Altınay 2008).

In the ANAP Era (1983–1991), which followed a period of intense politicisation ruptured by the junta regime, confessional citizenship promised a mode of belonging to the nation-state that was ostensibly emancipated from politics. Nevertheless, this type of citizenship was also contained and constrained by neoliberalism. Although the state benefited from confession as a disciplinary tool that produces and controls subjects, the role of public institutions in the creation and dissemination of the rituals and performances of confession was relatively limited. Moreover, these mostly forced exercises of confession functioned primarily on an individualised basis, and they could provide little access to the public sphere beyond the institutions where they took place, such as police stations, prisons or hospitals. The ultimate venue for the exercise of this neoliberal

[3]Although Ersoy's transition has already begun, other characters in the film refer to the main character with the male honorific 'bey'. More importantly, Ersoy's character presents as male at the end of the film. Hence, I use the gender pronoun 'he' to refer to the character.

mode of citizenship was the privately owned media outlets, where individuals engaged in confessional performances on a voluntary basis, perceiving them as a means to 'express themselves' – which, in effect, amounted to the performative constitution of the self – and exercise their individual liberties. In that sense, confession was not simply a duty to be fulfilled but also a desire to be satisfied. The confessional thus emerged as 'a cross-media style of art *and identity*' (Grobe 2017, xi).

In addition to the enhanced significance and sophistication of the everyday performances of confession, the ANAP Era also fostered a generation of professional performers whose careers largely relied on confessional practices. In part because the female body was conceptualised and produced as the primary object of sexual pleasure as well as a signifier of the nation's cultural borders and its honour, the stars of Turkey's era of confession were young and beautiful women. As models, actors, and singers, these women were often active in multiple fields. Nevertheless, they were recognised primarily as celebrities who sustained their fame through revealing their *mahram* – both in terms of information and in terms of the body. As they constantly narrated their glamorous yet dishonourable lives and rich partners in their interviews, films and songs, these demi-mondes fostered capitalistic desires – both as subjects who consume and as objects of consumption. Through their confessional performances, the women also emerged as role models, producing a desire in their audiences to invest in similar neoliberal strategies of subject-formation.

The sexual politics of confession did not operate through the bodies of (ostensibly) heterosexual and cisgender women only. As I have mentioned, Turkey's trans diva Bülent Ersoy created spectacular confessional performances. Less famous trans women performers and sex workers, including Seyhan Soylu, delivered confessions about their lives and sexualities not only in celebrity news but also in erotic magazines and reality shows. Although all its featured models were cis women, *Gözde Kadın* also published brief confessional stories about trans models in its very few pages devoted to other women. In part due to the rise of identity politics in post-coup Turkey, the 1980s was a time when critical feminism and LGBTIQ + activism began to gain power. In this context, trans and cisgender women – including the very celebrities who promoted the culture of confession – also produced texts and performances that challenged the gendered politics of confession and national abjection.

An important example of the feminist critique developed through confessional performances is the work of the singer, model, and actor Güngör Bayrak, also known as 'the Queen of Scandals'. As a model for *Gözde Kadın*, who also played in the television commercials for the magazine, Bayrak spectacularly reproduced the hegemonic politics of confession. In her work as a singer, however, she was more critical of the regime of confession as well as her role in it. Her autobiographical song *Benim Adım Güngör Bayrak* [My Name Is Güngör Bayrak] (1988), with its lyrics as well as its form, challenges the singer's hypersexualization and the commercialisation of her body in the Turkish entertainment industry. Bayrak's follow-up song *Leydi Şerife* [Lady Şerife] (1993) was a parody of the capitalist fairytale constructed around her life after she married into European royalty and literally became a lady.

As queer activists fought for visibility in Turkey's public sphere and sought to experience a sense of belonging to the nation-state, they conducted oral history projects and published autobiographical texts (Kuban 1989; Yüzgün 1987; Yüzgün 1988). These

works were often characterised by what José Esteban Muñoz (1999, 11) describes as 'disidentification': a cultural and political strategy adopted by minoritarian subjects who neither opt to assimilate within the dominant ideology nor strictly oppose it, but rather work on and against it. Some disidentificatory confessional texts and performances by queer subjects who attempted to mobilise memory for progressive social change were defined by fundamental ambivalences, as *Kraliçe Sisi* demonstrates.

Queer life writing and the politics of confession

Kraliçe Sisi was both a product of Turkey's age of confession and the culmination of Seyhan Soylu's self-branding efforts, which would make her one of the most influential trans women in the country. Soylu was born in 1967 to a lower-middle class family in Istanbul. At the age of sixteen, she left home and started doing sex work. Her rise to fame as the 'Queen of Transvestites' came in 1987, after she appeared on a reality show on the national public broadcaster TRT's main television channel, TRT 1. She was careful to use this opportunity to join the ranks of Turkey's few openly queer celebrities. Soylu thus began to attend public demonstrations and political events. She gave interviews to the press, where she narrated the intimate details of her life. In 1987, the erotic magazine *Playmen* published a four-page story on Soylu, featuring her glamour shots alongside a lengthy interview. Queer author, researcher, and activist Arslan Yüzgün's collection of stories about trans women, titled *Mavi Hüviyetli Kadınlar* [Women with Blue ID Cards] featured a story based on Soylu's failed romance with her late boyfriend. Her ID card was on the book's cover, highlighting the problems trans women experienced with the law. While expressing solidarity with Soylu and other trans women, the cover also used her celebrity status for promotional purposes. *Kraliçe Sisi* would acknowledge and praise Yüzgün's activism efforts (Oğuztan 1991, 127). Also in 1987, Soylu publicised her plans to publish an autobiographical book where she would narrate her sexual experiences with Turkey's elite, using the real names of the individuals involved (Magazin Servisi 1987, 1). After this interview, Soylu was taken into custody and interrogated. Possibly because of that experience, she postponed the project until 1991. Even then, she preferred to let the journalist Ümit Oğuztan become the author, instead of publishing the text under her own name, perhaps so she could deny responsibility for this controversial text. In the Turkish publishing industry, where editorial work was too often limited to proofreading, collaborating with a professional author might have also facilitated the production of a reader-friendly as well as affectively and politically powerful text.

On the back cover, Oğuztan details the methodology behind the book:

> *Kraliçe Sisi* is not an adventure novel written at a desk with the fiction of dreams and colourful fantasies. It is what objectively presents today and what will remain for tomorrow. The preparations for this book … It took innumerable phone calls, days of meticulous research on newspapers and magazines, hours of information exchange with twenty-five people, weeks spent on transcribing interviews that took weeks to conduct and filled many tapes, and nights and days of research and tracking. (Oğuztan 1991, 370)

With this methodology paragraph, Oğuztan performatively defines the book as a documentary novel and endows the text with a stronger image of objectivity and truth. The

eleven-page interview at the beginning of the book also serves this purpose. Building on such extensive research, the 363-page volume claims to document Seyhan Soylu's life from her birth until approximately the age of 24, which is when *Kraliçe Sisi* was published.

The novel begins by narrating Soylu's childhood traumas, fantasies, and sexual experiences. Following her hormone therapy and her rise to fame, *Kraliçe Sisi* details Soylu's relationship with her boyfriend Cengiz and their experiments with different drugs, ultimately leading to his death from an overdose. The rest of the book is devoted to Soylu's alleged sexual misadventures with Turkey's cultural, political, and business elite. In these mostly pornographic chapters, Oğuztan presents Soylu's life as a capitalistic success story that was – and for her, could only be – attained through sex work. While these chapters feature Soylu as a strong role model for other disenfranchised queer individuals in Turkey, they also interpellate them as capitalist subjects.

Kraliçe Sisi ends with the traumatic fulfilment of Soylu's desire for gender-affirming bottom surgery. Throughout the book, Soylu has an ambivalent relationship to her penis. In most of the text, she identifies as female and derives pleasure from being publicly recognised as such. Nevertheless, there are also passages where Soylu enjoys being recognised as male or looking androgynous, such as the section where she picks up young female hitchhikers and has sex with them. In these scenes of passing, the performance of gender is explicitly entangled with the performance of class and social status:

> Since she usually wore denim, the young girls would not notice her breasts hidden under the jacket, and they thought they were getting in the car of a rich and spoiled bourgeois youth. Her hair led some girls to assume that she was a musician (Oğuztan 1991, 220).

In addition to these casual sex partners, Soylu also has an underage girlfriend, who ends up committing suicide. The protagonist serves elite female clients as well, including the Minister of Labour and Social Security İmren Aykut. The name Soylu had chosen for the autobiography that she never published, *Bir Bedende İki Ruh* [*Two Souls in One Body*], also suggests a bigender rather than trans identification. As *Kraliçe Sisi* proposes how one may experience and embody multiple genders simultaneously, it encourages readers to conceptualise gender in more fluid terms. The gender-neutral nature of Turkish language facilitates the book's gender politics.

Despite her bigender identification, Soylu still undergoes gender-affirming surgery, after which she experiences psychological relief (Oğuztan 1991, 352) tempered by a new mode of suffering as well. Soylu's access to the Turkish jet set and her class mobility have primarily been through her sexuality, grounded in a specific body. Once she undergoes surgery, she loses her main source of income. The final pages of the book reflect a melancholic attachment to the lost penis and the financial opportunities it provided. In *Kraliçe Sisi*, even transitioning is thus understood primarily within the logic of neoliberal capitalism – although also accompanied by a criticism of it. In the end, craving for the sexual and media attention that she became addicted to, Soylu leaves her mother's apartment, telling her that she is going to join a state-regulated brothel:

> I will make them hang a huge photo of me on the door and write 'Queen Sisi works at No. 10. She does the guys she likes for free'. I will also let the whole press know. Everyone should read and take a lesson. (Oğuztan 1991, 362–363)

Once she gets in the taxi, however, she has no idea where she wants to go. With her neoliberal dreams of success crashed, she is completely lost.

As an auto/biographical text that is not only pornographic but also targets Turkey's elite, *Kraliçe Sisi* follows complex narrative strategies to critically engage with the politics of confession. To begin with, the book participates in the culture of confession. Nevertheless, this participation reflects a disidentificatory ambivalence. Using the media attention on Soylu and other queer subjects as a vantage point, Oğuztan (1991, 102) presents an open critique of the culture of confession and the media's role in it. He explains how the politics of censorship, the high price of paper caused by the state monopoly, and the increasing number of newspapers despite the shrinking market encouraged journalists to resort to celebrity journalism and sensational stories. The book thus deconstructs the culture of confession by exposing the broader political and economic systems that created and sustained it. Oğuztan also mentions how the news stories about Soylu replaced those about the systematic violence targeting LGBTIQ+ individuals and their activism efforts (1991, 103). The difference between *Kraliçe Sisi* and these stories – including the ones that would be published on the book, where the scandal effect would silence the political critique – demonstrate the problems with mainstream media outlets that now dominate the archives on queer sexualities in the long 1990s. The outreach and impact of the novel, however, was destined to be far more limited in comparison to the power of mainstream media.

Kraliçe Sisi is not only about the confessing subject; its notoriety comes from the figures Soylu claims to have had sexual relations with. They include ANAP politicians as well as prominent businesspeople and media moguls. These people, who benefited from the culture of confession because of its role in the broader neoliberal apparatus, did not commonly participate in this culture themselves. They were the presumably honourable citizens who not only belonged to the nation but also governed it. The book inverts these power hierarchies by dragging these powerful figures into the narrative of confession – and, most importantly, doing so by presenting them as queer subjects. Rendered vulnerable, they become extras in a spectacular performance of confession by a minoritarian subject – whom, for all we know, they may not even have met.

While *Kraliçe Sisi* is a memory project invested in a queer politics of resistance, this does not mean a complete devotion to liberatory politics. Several passages abound with misogynistic, ageist, and other discriminatory discourses. As the passage depicting an encounter between Soylu and Bülent Ersoy reveals, even transphobia is present:

> She was particularly staring at [Ersoy's] breasts; she could not take her eyes off her round, full, and firm breasts. But she knew that these beautiful looking breasts were filled with silicone. When she looked closely at her face, her admiration for Bülent completely disappeared. Despite the make-up and the generously applied foundation, which was easy to notice, the pitch-black beard line was easily seen. Her ostentatious attitude and behaviour, her feminine talk, her feminine walk, her feminine clothes, none of these … None of these could erase the ridiculousness and the conflict in her looks. Despite everything, one could understand that she was male … (Oğuztan 1991, 58).

Even as it advocates for trans rights, the book thus propagates transphobic discourses.

Kraliçe Sisi is particularly hostile to the Armenian community where, the author claims, many men earn money from procuring, including selling their wives (Oğuztan 1991, 194). As such, while it advocates for social acceptance and justice for queer subjects,

this memory project frames Armenians as the ultimate dishonourable national abjects. The book thus reflects a queer attempt to negotiate the politics of national abjection in Turkey not by challenging the notion of an ideal or acceptable citizen, but rather by emphasising ethnoreligious identity as opposed to gender and sexuality.

With these ambivalences, *Kraliçe Sisi* challenges the romantic conceptualisations of queer memory projects and demonstrates how such projects may not always reflect a complete investment in the goals of progressive politics. In the Turkish context, these ambivalences are by no means unique to *Kraliçe Sisi*. From the ultranationalist and eugenicist medical doctor, politician, historian, poet, memoirist, librettist, playwright, and translator Rıza Nur's (1879–1942) posthumously published archive to the popular historian Reşad Ekrem Koçu's (1905–1975) unfinished masterpiece *İstanbul Ansiklopedisi* [the Encyclopaedia of Istanbul], Turkey's queer archives of abjection have long reflected such dynamics (Altınay 2015; Altınay 2021; Sarıtaş 2020).

For a sexually and politically charged text like *Kraliçe Sisi* to survive censorship while producing the desired truth effect, Oğuztan followed complex strategies. To begin with, the author details the research behind the project and provides a sample interview with Soylu to ground the book in non-fiction methods, thus adorning it with an image of objectivity and truth. Contrary to Soylu's initial plans for her autobiography, in *Kraliçe Sisi* the names of virtually all persons, except Soylu, have been changed. Nevertheless, the aliases are either synonymous with or phonetically similar to the original names. The politician İmren Aykut, for instance, is presented under the synonymous alias Özen (Oğuztan 1991, 213). The photographer Erol Atar is given the similar sounding alias Birol (Oğuztan 1991, 331). With a pleasant political humour, the governing party ANAP takes on the name of AZAP, meaning torment (Oğuztan 1991, 112). As Della Pollock (1998, 95) argues:

> Performative rhetorics are performative to the extent that they operate from within circuitries of reader response. The realities they project assume negotiation. They involve the reader not as the subject/object of persuasion of a given reality claim but as a cowriter, co-constituent of an uncertain, provisional, normative practice.

Oğuztan's performative writing strategy, probably developed to avoid legal challenges, makes the book read like a puzzle that is mostly quite easy to solve. As the reader solves this puzzle and finds out who each character represents, their own participation in this process fosters the truth effect intended by the author. Facilitating the reader's active participation in the constitution of the text thus helps the performative construction of history as designed by Oğuztan and Soylu.

Changing the names of the persons involved would fail to be an adequate strategy to protect Oğuztan and Soylu from legal trouble. Presumably because they did not want the scandal to grow further or because they feared that Oğuztan and Soylu could present documentation concerning their sexual experiences, none of the persons mentioned in the book sued the duo. Nevertheless, a court case was filed on charges of obscenity. It was presumably after the case was initiated that the book began to be distributed with a note stamped on the third page:

> For you, my readers, I researched … I investigated … I made her tell … I wrote. Although it has not been written at a desk with the fiction of dreams, this is a novel. The protagonists are

> people among us. I kindly ask no one to take offense, except for Queen Sisi. That will upset me. (Oğuztan 1991, 1)

With the phrase 'this is a novel', Oğuztan did not necessarily make a descriptive claim; it was a performative attempt to reclassify the text in order to avoid further trouble. However, this attempt was futile. The book was soon banned, and all available copies were destroyed (Milliyet 1991, 10).

Pornography and queer readership

A key element of *Kraliçe Sisi*'s queer politics of resistance is the entanglement of a pornographic narrative with political discourses. This strategy is reminiscent of what James R. Kincaid (2004), in his study of child abuse narratives in Anglo-American cultures, terms 'pious pornography'. Kincaid uses the term to define the texts that allow the reader to experience sexual excitement and moral self-righteousness at the same time. Such entanglement of conservative discourses and pornographic narratives not only legitimises the sexual content but also assists the propagation of moral and political imperatives. In *Kraliçe Sisi*, Oğuztan blends the pornographic narrative with liberal and progressive discourses, presenting an example of what I call *liberal pornography*.

In *Kraliçe Sisi*, numerous sex scenes exist together with detailed accounts of the systematic discrimination and rights violations targeting LGBTIQ + individuals, such as unemployment, homelessness, domestic violence, bureaucratic obstacles to transitioning, and police brutality. Oğuztan thus emphasises the importance of individual freedoms and calls for social and political change. The excerpt at the beginning of this essay, where queer and working-class anger transforms into sexual aggression, is one of the many examples of this narrative style. In addition to the immediate issues related to LGBTIQ + subjects, Oğuztan also presents a broader critique of capitalism and social inequality as he describes the political atmosphere under the neoliberal regime, rife with political oppression, corruption, and media censorship. As such, the political critique serves to legitimise the book's pornographic content while the pornographic content, to an extent, popularises its scathing political critique. At a time when confession operated as a hegemonic disciplinary paradigm, the book's structure as a trans auto/biography mixed with celebrity gossip also informed these processes by helping the text reach a broader audience. Arguably, the hybrid nature of the book and its mainstream circulation also made it easier for the readers interested in queer erotica to access it without the fear of stigmatisation that could be caused by buying regular queer pornographic material – which was not easily available anyway. Furthermore, the book subjected the readers who would not necessarily be interested in queer pornography to this material and, in a sense, queered them.

The book's queering of its readers happens through providing material for identification and empathy as well as through the corporeal and affective dimensions of reading. In her description of reading as a form of identification, Hélène Cixous writes:

> One never reads except by identification. But what kind? When I say identification, I do not say loss of self. I become, I inhabit. I enter. Inhabiting someone at that moment I can feel myself traversed by that person's initiatives and actions. (Cixous and Clément 1996, 148)

Such a politics of identification attained via reading is one 'that dismantles the phenomenological universals of transcendent subjects and objects; that places identity in an unstable and contingent relation to identification; and that works close to the nerves dividing and connecting the psychic and the social' (Diamond 2007, 411). A critical deployment of empathy can also work in a similar manner. Building the empathetic equation on this conceptualisation of multiplicity rather than an attempt to understand the other as 'unified and transparently available to us' can help us 'experience affinities on a corporeal level with others through sensation' (Musser 2014, 25).

As the first popular auto/biographical text about a trans woman from Turkey, *Kraliçe Sisi* provided readers with the rare opportunity to identify and empathise with her. These were not the only ways the text could be read. Nevertheless, they were present and even fostered by the pornographic narrative, which intensifies the sensational flows that define the reading experience. Pornography, according to Michael Warner (2000, 185), 'enables unpredicted forms of experience' by providing the consumer with the opportunity to explore the diversity of sexual desires and practices of pleasure. This potential is embedded in pornography's affective and corporeal possibilities and its reliance on 'the readers' ability to somehow recognise and sense the sensations, desires and pleasures depicted in their own bodies' (Paasonen 2010, 66).

The queer pornographic sections of *Kraliçe Sisi*, which adhere to the genre conventions of pornography in Turkish literature at the time, construct an embodied and affective connection between the readers and the protagonist, possibly leading to sexual arousal at least in some readers whose gendered identifications and sexual desires would otherwise be on the normative spectrum. By producing embodied responses to queer pornography, the reading experience also potentially expands the practices of pleasure that the reader desires or imagines that they can derive pleasure from. Through such processes of queering, the book encourages the readers to imagine their sexual futures differently. Because sexuality plays a vital role in regulating the politics of citizenship and belonging, this imagination also has strong political implications – especially in terms of how individuals imagine the sexual borders of the nation.

An important aspect of queer non-fiction has been to help readers contextualise their experiences and imagine a queer community to which they may not otherwise have access (Altınay 2015, 97). This was particularly important in the pre-internet era. An interview with the trans activist Öykü Evren suggests how *Kraliçe Sisi* has served these purposes. As a teenager growing up in the 1990s, Evren was unable to make sense of her experiences. Only after she read the book that she came to self-identify as a trans woman and initiated her attempts to reconcile her gender and her life (Elçik 2007).

Kraliçe Sisi helped its trans and queer readers imagine alternative futures as well. The iconic side characters in the book are central to this process. The icon, as an exceptional moment, individual or event, is characterised by singularity yet it calls on universality (Fleetwood 2011, 46). The icon thus produces a singular and seemingly complete narrative about a historical period. The characters in *Kraliçe Sisi* are such icons. The man presented with the alias 'Ender Ak' in the excerpt I cited in the opening of this essay, for example, is Erol Aksoy. Known as one of the Prime Minister Turgut Özal's 'princes', Aksoy was the epitome of the Turkish yuppie. Other iconic figures in the book include the Prime Minister Özal's son-in-law Adnan Güngör, the feminist journalist Duygu Asena, the controversial religious leader Adnan Oktar, the socialite antique

dealer Ayşegül Nadir, and the singers Gönül Yazar, Nükhet Duru, and İbrahim Tatlıses. These figures, as icons, embody the history of Turkey in the long 1980s. By depicting them in a variety of non-normative sex scenes, *Kraliçe Sisi* not only challenges the public images of these individuals but also, thanks to their iconicity, presents an alternative account of Turkey's recent history – one in which queer subjects are not completely marginalised.

Queerness is 'a temporal arrangement in which the past is a field of possibility in which subjects can act in the present in the service of a new futurity' (Muñoz 2009, 16). By queering Turkey's icons, Oğuztan and Soylu presented the country's recent history in an unapologetically queer manner, expanding the field of possibility that the past is. With this strategy, they also made it possible for the queer subjects in the present (and the presents to come) to understand the world and contextualise their existence vis-à-vis the nation in a new light. By queering the past and by acknowledging the systematic rights violations and violence experienced by LGBTIQ + individuals and framing them within a broader sociopolitical context, this memory project encouraged queer subjects to imagine and invest in alternative futures. Nevertheless, neither such processes unfolded independently from neoliberalism, nor were the futures proposed by *Kraliçe Sisi* guided by a complete investment in progressive politics. As the book's presentation of the Armenian community as Turkey's ultimate national abjects and its transphobic passages demonstrate, *Kraliçe Sisi*'s politics were characterised by ambivalence. It is important to acknowledge these fundamental tensions in order to understand this queer literary text's call for justice as well as the broader complexities that characterise Turkey's queer history, the archives we have inherited, and the experiences of queer subjects in the present.

Conclusion

The long 1980s in Turkey was a period when confession emerged as a hegemonic governmental paradigm and formed the core of a specific mode of neoliberal citizenship. In this period, queer subjects not only contributed to the operation of confession as a disciplinary technology; they also challenged it through disidentificatory engagements with the politics and aesthetics of confession. *Kraliçe Sisi* was an important example of this subgenre of critical confessional texts and performances. The novel not only challenged the sociopolitical establishment but also exposed the very dynamics through which confession gained power as a disciplinary technology. While expanding the horizons of its readers' imagination for the future, the book provided its trans readers with a sense of community as well as a paradigm for understanding their experiences. Deploying the affective and corporeal powers of reading with the aid of pornography, the text also queered its readers by providing an opportunity for identification and empathy, and by producing non-normative sexual desires in and through their bodies.

Like many other disidentificatory texts and performances, the politics and aesthetics of *Kraliçe Sisi* were characterised by ambivalence. No matter how critical it was of the culture of confession, the book still participated in it. Rife with discriminatory discourses, the text is also far from a complete investment in the goals of liberatory politics. As such, *Kraliçe Sisi* diverges from most queer memory projects produced in Turkey since the 1980s, many of which are grounded in activist politics. The book also challenges the

scholarship on Islamic sexualities produced in the liberal Western and Turkish academia, where LGBTIQ + people from Islamicate contexts are predominantly presented as the victims of Israeli pink-washing, anti-immigrant sentiment in Europe, and post-9/11 border securitisation and surveillance in the United States while the many ways in which they invest in conservative discourses and policies are ignored (Altınay 2014). It is with such ambiguities, sexual thrills, and surprising puzzles that *Kraliçe Sisi* has now become part of a Turkish queer archive, inviting us to consider the different, at times unsettling forms queer literature and memory practices can take.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

Funding

This publication is part of the project 'ABJECT-ARCHIVES' - CUP G43C22003910001 which has received funding from NRRP Mission 4 - Component 2, Investment 1.2, 'Funding projects presented by young researchers' winners of European Research Council - ERC Starting Grant, supported by the MUR N. 247 19/08/2022 of the Directorate-General for Internationalization and Communication, funded by the European Union - NextGenerationEU.

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